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Irena Księżopolska

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Untwining the Threads in John Banville's *Birchwood*: False Shadows, Bogus Plots and What Lies Beyond Unreliability

Irena Księżopolska

Institute of English Studies, University of Warsaw, Warsaw, Poland

ABSTRACT

This paper proposes a radical re-interpretation of John Banville's *Birchwood*, a novel that may be seen to contain interpretative keys to the writer's universe. Almost all critics note that Gabriel Godkin's tale is a deliberately constructed fiction, but no one has as yet made an effort to decode the hidden essence of the narrative – and this is precisely what this essay aims to do. Rejecting the fundamental "revelation" of the narrative that Michael is his Gabriel's twin, I assert that Michael does not exist as a separate entity – he is Gabriel's imagined double, made up to fulfil his dark desires. Another grand fiction is the circus episode, which functions as a distorting mirror of the drama happening at home. By following clues in "Air and Angels" we may discover, for instance, that Gabriel is the one who killed his father. Finally, the essay discusses a metaphor of the two artistic modes found in the text: the puzzle-making vs. the juggling act. The latter consists of skillful replacement of one figure – scene – event – image with another, until all the reader sees is a brilliant hoop of light, a beautiful vision which seems to be uninterpretable.

Reverse Motion

There is a striking scene in *Birchwood*: Martha, the narrator's red-haired aunt who is actually supposed to be his mother, ascends the stairway backwards.[1] It is a moment of disaster, a moment in which death visits Birchwood – not as an unfortunate and unavoidable part of human existence, but as a supernatural intervention, or, rather, a literary invention, "spontaneous combustion" – which, most likely, is a cover-up for the political violence. The scene, with its backward motion, gives off a feel of time itself trying to turn back in shock. Echoes and reflections, a series of resemblances which seem to construct a strange, wonderful symmetry, are laid out around this scene by the crafty narrator, who only feigns his distress and inability to control the story. The moment is hauntingly familiar to those who still remember watching films on videotapes. Rewinding the tape with the picture still on screen, we would watch that strange reversed movement, to a moment from which we would press "play" once again, perhaps hoping for a different turn of events than what we had just seen.

Perhaps, this is precisely the role of this scene. It is a moment from which the narrator "replays" the events of his tale, remodeling them more to his liking. Whatever happened "in reality" – that is, in the peculiar reality of the novel – is now replaced with the fiction Gabriel creates, a fantasy of alternative existence. The novel replicates itself: from the frame established at the beginning, when we see Gabriel deciding to write his story (level one), it runs through a sequence of fragmented scenes, which the narrator tries to elaborate upon and explain, or, perhaps, to make into a more fantastic puzzle than his boring – or embarrassing – family life (level two). Once he arrives at the scene described above, he seems to introduce a branching off, suspending his previous narrative and moving in a different

CONTACT Irena Księżopolska i.ksiezopolska2@uw.edu.pl Institute of English Studies, Faculty of Modern Languages, University of Warsaw, Dobra 55, Warsaw 00-312, Poland

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direction (level 3). Granny Godkin's death, fantastic as it is, will appear less unbelievable than the death of Martha in the flames of the burning hayshed – a balletic, impossible self-immolation, (im) passively watched by all the other characters as a fragment of a staged tragedy – a play in which the audience becomes as stylized as the actors. Still earlier, there are scenes of quarrels or sudden transformations, which appear similar to the set pieces from various melodramas played on the provisional stage of Prospero's Magic Circus (level 4). The whole adventure of the circus, neatly separated from the family saga, will be another frame – but by this time, multiplication of sub-stories, sub-levels and additional frames is so confusing that arithmetic enumeration is of little help.

The novel consists of three parts: "The Book of the Dead," family history and family drama, seemingly conventional, but animated through Banvillian painterly gaze; "Air and Angels," a fantastic tale of a traveling circus, picaresque and horrific in its depiction of violence and famine, and named, oddly, after John Donne's love poem; and "Mercury," a return home and a wrapping up of the tale, the burying of the dead and the lining up of the resolutions to the plot's riddles, which really solve nothing at all. The first and the last parts seem to reflect each other across the weird tragicomedy of the middle, but "Air and Angels" is yet another broken mirror reflecting fragments of "The Book of the Dead." Or is it "Mercury" that is reflected across the novel, in reverse?

There is another inverted scene, rendered not as a direct memory (though, of course, none of Gabriel's memories are what they seem to be), but as though in a "subordinate clause" of the story, as a response to Martha's accusatory voice:

> "I saw you with the blotting paper." This was a reference to my effort to read the smudges on Papa's green blotter by holding it before a mirror one day after I had overheard talk of his famous will. I thought I had not been observed. It hardly mattered, since all the mirror gave me back were blots turned the right way about but still illegible.[2]

This inversion is an example of a would-be symbol that turns out to be quite meaningless. Gabriel's efforts to read the blotter to learn the content of his father's testament may be seen as an attempt to read his future. The blotter, however, shifts him back into the past – everything has happened already, all this is a repetition. The mirror, which was supposed to fix matters by re-inverting the inversion, produces a travesty, an involution – "blots turned the right way about but still illegible."

This scene offers another thread to follow. Both the blotter and the mirror appear in Vladimir Nabokov's poem, "An Evening of Russian Poetry":

> My back is Argus-eyed. I live in danger.
> False shadows turn to track me as I pass
> and, wearing beards, disguised as secret agents,
> creep in to blot the freshly written page
> and read the blotter in the looking glass.
> And in the dark, under my bedroom window,
> until, with a chill whirr and shiver, day
> presses its starter, warily they linger
> or silently approach the door and ring
> the bell of memory and run away.[3]

Who are these secret agents? Not critics – Nabokov would not fear them. Nor are they readers, however tempting it might be to think so – they would not trouble the writer's memory. If the phrase "my back is Argus-eyed" refers to the writer's own fears, then might it also suggest the tendency to constantly look back into the past, or into an invented (inverted?) version of one's own life? These agents, then, would be his own characters, versions of self, who seem to be at the mercy of their creator, but who may also turn the tables and pursue him out of their story-worlds into his.

This metafictional element is certainly shared by all of Banville's fictions – more than that, it is made into something of a continuous structural feature. Banville does not construct a separate and insular story-world for each of his books, but rather a series of interconnected worlds which are somehow both parallel to ours and at times seem to merge and overlap with reality as we know it. His characters – heroes and heroines bearing the same, or very similar names, appear in novel after novel,

and yet, they are always slightly different versions of their own "selves" already familiar to the reader. Discussing the tangle of connections in Banville's early fictions, Francis C. Molloy states: "Certainly, one often feels that Banville is playing elaborate fictional games with his readers, setting up ambiguous situations which cannot be resolved."[4] Indeed, when the novels are grouped into *Science Tetralogy*, *Frames Trilogy*, etc., there is always an element of sleight of hand. *Doctor Copernicus* and *Mefisto* – supposedly parts of *Science Tetralogy* – are worlds apart; Freddy of *The Book of Evidence* speaks with a voice starkly different from the Freddy of *Ghosts*, or "Morrow" of *Athena*, and when he reappears in *Singularities*, everything is once more familiar and yet very strange – "a familiar world transformed, a transubstantiated world."[5] These clusters of worlds hang together as if they were so many parallel universes, but even this is too simple an explanation of their nature. They are worlds within worlds, but without the possibility to decipher which one is the frame and which is the embedded one; they are doubles of a bogus original; they are alternative possibilities of the same stories which turn out to be quite different, once granted their space and time.

Birchwood is an early text and seems to stand apart from the constellations that begin with *The Science Tetralogy*. Yet, in *The Newton Letter*, we encounter Charlotte Lawless (the family name of Gabriel's mother, Beatrice). And though Gabriel Godkin will not reappear in later books, Gabriel Swan, a genius mathematician, deeply troubled, shifting between the world of pure ideas and the underworld of dark desires in *Mefisto*, may be seen as his reincarnated version.[6] That latter Gabriel will have no face, burned beyond all recognition in a fire that destroys his past – and fire, of course, is the scarlet thread that strings together many separate strands in *Birchwood*.[7] I will not claim that John Banville had already planned his future novels for the next fifty years at the time he was writing *Birchwood*, but I would suggest that in this early novel we can find some clues to his peculiar, singular patterns – or, rather, some hints and pointers for those who like to wander through fictional worlds admiring their architecture and getting lost in the labyrinths of narrative paths, interpretative by-ways and false alleys.

But to return to that scene with Gabriel reading the blotter – viewed through the prism of Nabokov's poem, it becomes reconfigured: rather than attempting to learn the will of his father, the boy is trying to understand the intentions of his author. Gabriel is the one who is deeply troubled by his recollections – perhaps, because he carries the burden of the opulent and suffocating literary tradition, and the impossible burden of Irish history; or, perhaps, it is the burden of the fictitious history, terribly real to *him*. That is why he might be tempted to "silently approach the door and ring// the bell of memory and run away." In this essay, I am not concerned with what John Banville might wish to remember or forget – I would not presume to make guesses about his intentions.[8] The trick of metafiction is to transfer the troubles of the characters to other levels of discourse, and vice versa. Thus, that lingering silent presence underneath the window is also Gabriel's problem – in fact, there is more than one scene replicating this very situation within the plot of the novel (Michael softly whistling and chanting under Gabriel's window in the first part; Michael glimpsed in the garden in the third). And this fear of "the secret agents" is strange, since by the time Gabriel comes to write his story, most of its characters are dead. Michael – that mysterious evil twin – is chased away by the narrator, and what remains of Prospero's Magic Circus is "melted into air, into thin air" leaving "not a rack behind."[9] There is no one left to contradict the narrator, no one to spy on him. Why, then, this paranoia, this obsession with the past, this ancient-mariner-like insistence on grabbing the reader (the listener) by the hand? "Lift your head! Look!" he cries, and then again: "Listen, listen . . . "[10] He must speak, and he must convince whoever is there to listen that he did search for meaning, even if he failed in his endeavor.

Rüdiger Imhof writes that the search for meaning in the novel is shifted from the hero to the reader.[11] I would add that this is a constant feature of Banville's worlds. He admits this in his interviews – "Every reader remakes the work (. . .) and I love that,"[12] going even so far as to claim that he never re-reads his novels and probably gets things wrong when he alludes to them[13] (he does not). However, this would mean that no reading, however "narrow" or "naïve," can be misguided – or if so, only in the eyes of another reader, with their own (mis)reading of the text. Those who read

Birchwood as a Gothic detective story are not wrong: Gabriel clearly intends us to see his narrative that way – the reader is to collect clues. But this may be done on the level of the plot and, simultaneously, on the meta-level: the more literary conventions, tropes, borrowings from other works of art we recognize, the better. In the end, it is up to us to choose a pattern of interpretation, either by combining all these elements or by stripping away the layers of palimpsest that seem to obscure the meaning.

In my (mis)reading, the plot Gabriel constructs in his narrative is bogus, though I still see the text as a detective novel of a kind. Nor do I wish to remain strictly on the meta-level, ignoring the sinister workings of the tale – there is a story-world which exists and is obliquely reflected by Gabriel's narrative, and my purpose is to uncover as much of that world as possible. Therefore, I will not accept Gabriel's glib solution and instead go after some clues that have attracted my attention. I believe that Gabriel's deeds burden him so much that no life is possible outside memories; there is a compulsion to speak, imposing order upon his recollections, yet he seeks to hide his truths underneath the plots of family quarrels and bitter struggles, the fantastic allure of the quest conducted within the frame of the circus with its gloriously grotesque characters; and then, he seeks to bury it still deeper beneath the Proustian reflection on "time misplaced"[14] and the philosophical notion of circular history, with all the national terrors.

The Silenced Story

What, then, is he hiding? Firstly, there is no twin within the "reality" of *Birchwood*: Michael's existence is as bogus as that of Rose, the imaginary sister that Gabriel allegedly sets out to find when he leaves Birchwood. Everything Michael is said to be doing in the novel is either a potential action of Gabriel (a fantasized possibility, his impossible desire), or Gabriel's (mis)deed shifted over to that convenient "evil twin." In fact, this is already signaled by the epigraph to the novel: "I hate and I love, and how? I cannot tell you/Only I feel it, and I am torn in two."[15]

This would mean that Rose functions only as a decoy: when the reader is told that she never existed, it seems to assuage the suspicions of the fatuous nature of the twin theme. While at this point Michael's nonexistence may seem a wildly speculative idea, evidence for it is recoverable, scattered as it is through the narrative – I am only pursuing a thread intuited by other critics. For instance, Francis C. Molloy concludes that in Birchwood "the story, characters and themes are all invention, all fabrication"[16]; Mika Momoo sees "the whole story [as] rather preposterous and baffling."[17] Joseph McMinn, noting Gabriel's admissions of constructing "a wholly illusory past,"[18] writes that "his story is an imaginative version of the facts, measured and arranged according to the dictates of perception and desire."[19] However, while McMinn's assumption is that this fictionalizing is fueled by the narrator's need "for emotional and imaginative consolation without denying the horrors of existence,"[20] I would argue that there is a very strong, unassuageable feeling of guilt, and it is the main force behind his unreliable "confessions."

Secondly, there is no escape with the circus. Gabriel is simply sent off to school – a circumstance articulated by his father just before the fantastic scene of the hayshed fire.[21] He does come back to Birchwood from time to time, probably during vacations, and some of the episodes narrated earlier actually belong to these visits. How do we know that? Gabriel mentions that he won over Rosie, his "country darling,"[22] by talking to her about algebra.[23] But how did he come to learn it in the first place? Martha, his only teacher, certainly could not give him any knowledge of that kind – her instruction was limited to reading books of fiction to him. This is one of the indications that Gabriel did not stay in Birchwood all the time before meeting Rosie. The circus, then, is a wonderful alternative story he creates for himself, to escape the boredom of the formal education – and, perhaps, for other, more weighty reasons as well.

It is hardly necessary to go over the obvious signs of unreality of the circus crew and their stories, but I will mention just a few. The very title of this part – "Air and Angels" – suggests the insubstantiality of this adventure. The names of the characters in that episode are all too transparent: Silas ("of the woods") looks very much like a satyr, if not Pan himself; Angel, who cooks and generally keeps things

running, seems to be a dark parody of the Victorian "Angel in the House"; the twins Ada and Ida seem to be a re-spelling of Aid, split up into opposites – hellish Ada and meek Ida; Magnus ("the great") is Gabriel's favorite figure – a magnificent storyteller, a clown, as well as a magician (and the name aptly echoes "Magus"); Sybil, always angry and miserable, and terribly beautiful, is seen by Gabriel to stand for Ireland itself; Mario the juggler seems short for "marionette"; the names of the androgynous wicked twins, Justin and Juliette, are borrowed from de Sade.[24] The appearance of the circus in Birchwood at the moment of Gabriel's birth (of which he speaks with great confidence without having witnessed any of it) and its reappearance within the property at the exact time he comes back to the house strongly hint at the constructedness of the story. Most importantly, the circus crew members bring about events, often momentous, by simply speaking about them. Angel says, "no spuds," and the potato famine begins,[25] Magnus tells a story of an exploding coffin (left unnarrated by Gabriel),[26] and later it is played out before the reader's eyes at Rosie's funeral. Moreover, the alias taken up by Gabriel for his performances in the circus, Johann Livelb, is a transparent anagram of John Banville. Many critics comment on the deliberate quality of metafictionality in this part of the book,[27] yet without going so far as to state that Gabriel invented it altogether. I do not, however, wish to dismiss the middle section of the novel as inessential – in fact, it is crucial for the current investigation. In it, Gabriel creates doubles or composites of his family members and acquaintances and drops hints of what could have happened in the silenced story of his life at Birchwood.

Furthermore, Cotter's figure – a character outside the circus adventure – I believe to be as bogus as the circus crew. He clearly belongs to the generation that came and went long before Gabriel's time. Like the circus troupe, he comes as a proxy for someone else, someone who murdered Gabriel's father. This murder is one of the key mysteries of the story. And it is my belief that the murderer is no other than Gabriel himself. And while his narrative cunningly suggests that it was Cotter who must have smothered Joseph Godkin in his bed, there are several clues to suggest that Gabriel Godkin's hand held that pillow. It is already suggested in the naming games the novel plays – Gabriel is named, it seems, after the original Godkin, who took over Birchwood by doing away with *Joseph* Lawless.

Another mystery – and here one must proceed cautiously, since Gabriel seems to obscure his tracks again and again – is the relative positions and respective fates of Martha and Beatrice. For this, a careful analysis of the clues from the "Air and Angels" will be necessary. Sybil, the red-haired beauty, cruel and cold, and yet passionate and mournful, seems to share many features with Martha, and in this text of echoes and reflections functions as Martha's double. Beatrice, on the other hand, is mirrored in the image of Ida, a dark-haired twin of Ada. Ida possesses a kind of innocence and simplicity that allies her with Gabriel's "mama," she is also not fully self-aware, or slightly mad – in a childish, harmless manner.[28] However, as we shall see, Ida is also connected with another character from "The Book of the Dead" part – Rosie, Gabriel's first love. These connections are essential and will be studied in detail further in this essay.

Yet another, seemingly unrealistic element of the text is the timing of the novel. It is deliberately confusing: the Great Famine (1847–1852), described as part of Gabriel's experience, is also mentioned as something that established the fortunes of the Godkin family back in the time of Gabriel's great-great-grandfather. Calculating from 1847, adding twenty years for each generation and fifteen years for Martha's return, we end up around 1925–6, which might work, as this was the year of a "minor" famine in Ireland due to heavy rainfall. However, the severity of the famine in the text is certainly beyond the historical reality of 1925. And what about all those violent men in women's clothing who invade the story, the Molly Maguires, agrarian activists fighting against enclosures, who disappeared toward the end of the 19th century? It is tempting to read this symbolically, as an allusion to the circularity of history, the inescapable horrific cycle of violence. Elke D'hoker states that "the circular structure of Birchwood reflects on the virtual impossibility of exact historical representation."[29] However, it might also be that this grotesque cyclicity is obscuring something in the text. I would claim that the actual timeframe is The Troubles of the late 1960s and 1970s.[30] These events must have been strongly on Banville's mind when he was working on the novel, since at the same time he was a copy-editor for the Irish Press, reading and editing every night news reports on what happened in the

country. In a recent interview, he calls this period "the Wars of Religion [in] their last flare" and "terrible times."[31] And while Gabriel focuses on famine, it is the presence of the British soldiers and terrorist violence (explosions) that are far more important for the story.[32] Explosions are a theme that links many key figures, from Granny Godkin (dying of spontaneous combustion), through Magnus (who tells the story of an exploding coffin and then dies of an exploding bullet in his head), to Rosie (exploding in her coffin). And it is the British soldiers who rape and beat Ida to death.[33]

Finally, I would risk asserting that the narrative does not end in failure, despite all that Gabriel states. The title of the last part is "Mercury," and that character will reappear under an alternative alias in the future novels. Hermes is the narrator of *The Infinities* and one of the voices in *The Singularities*, and he might be behind Freddy's self-estranged voice in *Ghosts*. He is also a shadowy figure in the play Alexander Cleave is performing in *Eclipse*, when the actor loses his ability to act. Through his narrative in *Birchwood*, Gabriel manages to turn himself into Mercury, the storyteller and the deceiver, a god who can command time and space and who leads the souls of the dead into the underworld, the messenger of doom and the changeable, volatile element. Forging such an identity is quite a feat.

Structured Unreliabilities

It is curious just how willing Gabriel is to admit his artistic failure, to embrace the chaos of his existence, confessing to having meddled with facts, invented characters and scenes, and constructed his narrative out of bits of other stories read and misremembered. And this is the stance that is characteristic of all Banville's narrators – they are all, without exception, *artistes manqués*, lost in the labyrinth of their own stories, with too many threads in their hands to lead them to the goal of their quests. Yet, there is a strange, haunting glimmer in this novel that suggests that, perhaps, not all is lost:

> Listen, listen, if I know my world, which is doubtful, but if I do, I know it is chaotic, mean and vicious, with laws cast in the wrong moulds, a fair conception gone awry, in short an awful place, and yet, and yet a place capable of glory in those rare moments when a little light breaks forth, and something is not explained, not forgiven, but merely illuminated.[34]

The resolution presented in a single stark page at the end of the novel is suspended in the text without proper exposition. We are suddenly told "how things really are," but not how Gabriel managed to learn them. None of it comes as a real surprise: we might have suspected earlier from the hints dropped here and there that Martha and Joseph were incestuous lovers; certainly, the existence of Rose was highly unlikely from the beginning, since the idea first appeared to Gabriel in his delirium; Beatrice's madness also appeared a touch too methodical, as if she were finally adopting a family trait, a convenient convention to liberate herself from her unfulfilled desires and get the luxury of revenge which her mild nature denied her. Yet, one thing that should have been mentioned by the narrator and was not is the resemblance between him and Michael, which must have been obvious to him from the start. In fact, he did describe Michael, but not himself, not until the very end of the novel. This is the thorn in the reader's flesh – the obnoxious deceit, clearly deliberate on the narrator's part. All the other elements seem to be accounted for, even if it is a little strange that it takes Gabriel so long to solve the riddle.

Michael, that "real" twin, then, is where the text goes awry. The narrator has the nerve to reveal to us in the end that "Yes, he was my brother, my twin, I had always known it, but would not admit it, until now, when the admitting made me want to murder him"[35]; and "There is no girl. There never was. I suppose I always knew that, in my heart. I believed in a sister in order not to believe in him, my cold mad brother."[36] If Rose seemed implausible, a phantom created by a feverish mind, Michael remains in the story, shadowing the narrator from the moment Martha comes back from her exile. Apparently, this happens fifteen years after the birth of the boys (angry Martha screams to Joseph: "Fifteen years you kept me stuck in that place, no money, no friends, and you only coming when you felt like it.").[37] And this is another strangeness: when Gabriel escapes to join the circus, he seems much younger than the sixteen

or seventeen years old he must be. The circus members treat him as a little boy; he seems not old enough to understand what is happening around him – the lewd jokes, for example, seem lost on him. Immediately before his escape, during the hayshed fire, a fireman carries him away in a blanket, as though he were a small child. When he begins his narration, on the other hand, he seems much older and wiser, as though he had time to travel the world – decidedly further than Prospero's circus could have gone, and longer than the single year the circus adventure covers. While he claims to be writing his text immediately after the slaughter of the Lawless family – the last "event" described in the novel – there are references to books not yet written at the beginning of the 20th century.[38]

The narrator does offer an explanation: "The name is Godkin, Gabriel. I feel I have already lived for a century and more. This can only be an advantage. Am I mad, starting again, and like this? I have seen terrible things. It amazes me that I was allowed to survive to tell of them. Mad indeed."[39] Dismissing the admission of madness as reductive, we can accept the suggestion of being at variance with the clock time. Gabriel might be living his life as a mosaic of events, actual, historical and literary – hence the strangeness of his narrative. Most likely, he is an old man when he begins to write his story – perhaps this is the end of his life, and memory blurs together the collective and the personal. However, he may still be young, but as he begins writing down his "confessions," the stance of an old man is adopted by him as part of the convention. Time is a tricky subject in Banville's books, a dimension with many layers and nooks, a texture on which "memory snags her nails."[40]

The craftiness of the narrative, the number of historical and literary allusions, and the use of various tropes, conventions, genres have been noted by multiple critics.[41] Banville explains in an interview: "I deliberately chose stock characters, caricatures, the beautiful, suffering mother, the hard-drinking, cruel father, the sensitive son, the ghastly grandparents, the comic servants, and I put them all in a big house, the most clichéd thing in Irish fiction. And then I tried to subvert the type, to make something else of it."[42] The list of borrowed items is extended in another interview by "the quest, the lost child, the doppelgänger."[43] Of course, the last entry seems the most interesting in the context of this essay, and the kind of subversion that is accomplished by Banville through his devious narrator is precisely my subject.

It is not enough to say that Gabriel is an unreliable narrator – he is well beyond that. It does not seem to make any sense trying to establish intentionality, or failures of memory, etc., behind his clearly fabulous and stylized account. Gabriel himself seems less of a person than a voice,[44] or a whole host of voices, melting into each other, then separating once more. He crafts for himself a story that is so grotesque and fantastical that all his illusionist tricks within it appear absolutely natural. The rules that should govern the novel are negated by its hybridity. The most fitting description of that peculiar artistic style is contained in the picture of the wood at the beginning of the novel:

> Our wood was one of nature's cripples. (. . .) Under a couple of feet of soil there was a bed of solid rock, that intractable granite for which the area is notorious. On this unfriendly host the trees grew wicked and deformed, some of them so terribly twisted that they crawled horizontally across the hill, their warped branches warring with the undergrowth, while behind them, at some distance, the roots they had struggled to put down were thrust up again by the rock, queer maimed things. Here too, on the swollen trunks, were lymphatic mushrooms flourishing in sodden moss, and other things, reddish glandular blobs which I called dwarfs' ears. It was a hideous, secretive and exciting place, I liked it there, and when, surfeited on the fetid air of the lower wood, I sought the sunlight above the hill, there on a high ridge, to lift my spirit, was the eponymous patch of birches, restless gay little trees which sang in summer, and in winter winds rattled together their bare branches as delicate as lace.[45]

What is curious in this description is not only the wonderfully Gothic imagery, but the self-consciousness of the language – the use of the word "eponymous" signals the narrator's awareness of the game. Eponymous with what? Is it the name of the wood, the name of the estate, or, perhaps, the title of the novel? Imhof lists other instances which demonstrate Gabriel's uncommon metafictional self-consciousness – alliterative passages, commentary on the conventions, conspicuous

intertextuality, concluding that Gabriel's account is "a deliberate textual construct involving a certain amount of play."[46] But what is his game?

Naming Games and the Godkin Twins

Besides the elements mentioned by Imhof, Gabriel's aching self-consciousness is also apparent in the way he introduces himself, using that round-about "the name is."[47] It resembles Melville's famous "Call me Ishmael," and seems to suggest "this is my name within the space of this book, use it, but I know better than to attach myself to it." Godkin as a surname invites further suspicion. In *The Infinities* and *The Singularities*, a similar name will feature: Adam Godley, a mathematician whose Brahma theory will cause a radical contraction of the world, and who will be closely connected with Gabriel Swan of *Mefisto*, perhaps plagiarizing Gabriel's ideas.[48] Both "Godkin" and "Godley" are mocking names, suggesting the demiurgical status of the characters, which is at variance with godliness understood as goodness.

Once we admit that "Gabriel Godkin" is as provisional as "Ishmael," the need to figure out the significance of this alias becomes more pressing. And since Gabriel appears in tandem with Michael, this must be a clear reference to the two archangels. Archangel Gabriel is "the messenger" – to Mary, and to the prophets – neatly linking with "Mercury" as another alias of the narrator. He is also one of the archangels announcing the Apocalypse, chiming with the subject of Gabriel's narrative. "Michael" is even more interesting. It means "strongman," as in "God is the Strongman," which seems to hint at a connection with the somewhat incongruous historical character of Strongbow.[49] A statue of Strongbow greets Gabriel in the town to which he flees from Birchwood; next to it, a figure dressed up as that same hero appears, and this masquerade is extended by many others in a march on the holiday of the Virgin Mary. Significantly, "Strongbow" calls Gabriel "whelp," echoing Joseph Godkin's reference to Michael.

More importantly, there is another reading of the name: "Michael" means "who is greater than God?" with the implied answer of "*no one*." And this, precisely, is the most potent meaning for my interpretation. This is the first hint that Michael as a person does not exist within Gabriel's world. He is invented to shoulder the blame for everything that goes wrong, as the convenient evil double, as the sinister secret sharer, or as someone who gets to do what Gabriel is not *strong* enough to accomplish.

It is curious how Gabriel speaks about Michael's birth, calling it "an arrival": "[Martha's] firstborn arrived that spring day of storm and panic when the circus invaded Birchwood, and Papa, dismounting that evening by the fountain, looked up and saw an infant lifted in the window. However, that infant was I, but more of that presently."[50] The birth of Michael is seamlessly conflated with that of Gabriel, and while it would make some sense if the boys were twins, it also works even better if "an infant" is single, and it is Gabriel.

It seems likely that Martha left immediately after giving birth to Gabriel, leaving the boy behind, to be raised as the child of Beatrice and Joseph – Gabriel's childhood memories of the idyll he enjoys at Birchwood seem to suggest that he was there all along. Once a reconciliation between Martha and her family takes place, she tries to oust Beatrice out of her place in the affections of Joseph – and of Gabriel. The quiet, gentle Beatrice would stand in stark contrast to Martha, volatile and violent, as all the Godkins. As Martha reenters Gabriel's life, claiming him back, mistreating him by word and action, and as he becomes aware of her incestuous affair with Joseph, she seems more and more odious to him. He insists on calling Beatrice his "mama," even though at the moment of writing, he claims to know that Martha is his birth mother. And in retrospect, as he turns back to look at all those figures lost in irretrievable past, the harmless and defenseless Beatrice would gain an almost saintly glow, and he would wish to re-insert himself into the picture as her protector, her knight-errant, through a story of fanciful quest in search of her lost self, half-visible in the old photograph – although he pretends to think that it is not her, but his lost twin sister who is captured in that image. In short, Gabriel would see Martha as an intruder, the one who destroys the delicate balance at Birchwood, and blame her

appearance and her influence for everything that goes wrong, seeking to burden her with the responsibility for his own transformation – for the emergence of that "evil twin," who is now always there, to observe everything with a mocking eye.

If we review the narrative, it will strike us how passive Gabriel seems to be. His only adventures are within the sphere of the circus, and even there, he is more of a witness than an active participant. The entire first part features him as a bored, sullen, mostly silent child. The second part shows him coming to Birchwood too late, after the atrocities are almost over. Michael, on the other hand, is supposed to be responsible for so many of the terrible events: the death of Martha (even if indirectly), the takeover of the estate by the rebels, the slaughter of the Lawlesses. He pops up at the moment of intimacy between Gabriel and Rosie, breaking the charm; he suggests to Gabriel that his sister was stolen by the circus, sending him on his mad quest . . . Doppelgängers are an old trick, and Gabriel simply uses it as a perfect way to make a confession without confessing anything: it is *the other* who is responsible.

When he tells the reader that he always knew that "there never was" a twin sister, that he simply adopted this idea because he could not live with the knowledge of such a brother as Michael, he proves his craftiness as an illusionist. In fact, this whole misguided quest is a way to distract the reader from the obvious *duplicity* of the "twin" trope. When we feel satisfied by the final admission that "there is no girl," we forget to question that other, so much more important (non)existence – of "*no one*" who simply disappears at the end of the book:

> His grin widened. He had not changed. His red hair was as violent as ever, his teeth as terrible. I might have been looking at my own reflection. (. . .) On the bed Papa lay in his black suit and waistcoat with a blue face and staring eyes and a thick protruding tongue. Michael stepped out of the shadows and smiled down upon him faintly.

"Our father, which art dead."

He looked up at me and the smile faded, and there again in his eyes was that icy white fury as of old. From its sheath, I slipped the gleaming panther and clasped it in both hands above my head so tightly that the blade shivered and sang under the strain. He stared intently at the wicked weapon and glided backward slowly, slowly, toward the open doorway, into the shadows, until only his anguished eyes remained, burning in the dark, and at last they too were extinguished. I lowered the knife and spoke aloud my own name seven times and listened to the echoes, and then returned through the wood and across the garden to Birchwood.[51]

This looks like a rewritten scene from Poe's "William Wilson" (the weapon, the mirror), or any of the later Doppelgänger stories or films. But in this particular setting, with this pair of names, there is an added layer of significance: who is greater than the god of the story? No one. This meeting of the opposites over the dead body of the father, and the phrase which is spoken aloud *without attribution* – all this seems to confirm that there is only one living person in the room, the murderer. Then, speaking his name – *which one?* - seven times, the narrator performs a sort of exorcism, and the evil shadow recedes. Note that backward movement again.

Might then "Gabriel" be the invented name, while "Michael" is the real one? Possibly, but this hardly matters. Both names are there only as parts of the riddle. Note that in the exorcism scene, the narrator simply says "my own name" – pretending to drop all aliases and disguises adopted at the beginning, and yet *not* letting the reader into his secret. Perhaps, this was what Banville meant when he said in the interview with Imhof: "I like the end of Birchwood, where everything is wrapped up, and nothing is wrapped up."[52]

A Lost Child, a Girl Misplaced in Time

There are three semi-angelic female figures in the novel: Beatrice and Rosie, appearing in "The Book of the Dead," and Ida, one of the circus twins in "Air and Angels." Rosie, also dark-haired, is quite distinct in temperament from Beatrice – she is a "country darling," pretty, but coarse, given to bad moods and angry gestures, while Beatrice is all patience and self-sacrifice. However, Rosie and Gabriel's "mama" are linked through the photograph of Beatrice as

a child, which, as the narrator claims, inspires his search for a girl "misplaced in time."[53] Gabriel names his invented sister Rose, a name which almost coincides with Rosie. When Ida appears within "Air and Angels," her childlike innocence, which makes her continuously open to the wonder of the world, her gentleness and sweetness seem to set her apart from all others. She is the figure in which Beatrice is recreated by Gabriel, with tenderness and longing, as well as guilty remorse. He speaks of her with the pain of loss, which hints that she might have been the very girl he was searching for. If the entire quest episode is to be read as an invented story that obliquely hints at the suppressed truths, there might be a peculiar suggestion here.

Ida dies in a terrible, heartbreaking moment – just when the world seems at its most benign, she is found by three British soldiers, raped and beaten to death. Gabriel is with her when this happens – they are picking blackberries together, but for some reason, they get separated, and when Gabriel finds her again, she is past all help. This seems a little strange – he is there to witness her death, but not to save her.

Rosie, his first love, is still a child, and yet world-wise, as a country girl would be; and when Gabriel makes his discoveries of female anatomy, he is surprised to find "not so much a hole as a wound."[54] It is a curious way to speak of a vagina, and suggests an injury – possibly, an intimation of what is to happen later – or has already happened. Gabriel meets Rosie at the harvesting of the blackcurrants, referred to by his father as "blackers":

> Down in the green gloom under the bushes, where spiders swarmed, the berries were gorgeous, achingly vivid against the dusty leaves, but once plucked, and in the baskets, their burnished lustre faded and a moist whitish film settled on the skin. If they were to be eaten, and we ate them by the handful at the start, it was only in that shocked moment of separation from the stems that they held their true, their unearthly flavour. Then the fat beads burst on our tongues with a chill bitterness which left our eyelids damp and our mouths flooded, a bitterness which can still pierce my heart, for it is the very taste of time.[55]

The bitter yet delicious taste is connected with the evanescence of beauty – or with the guilt that mixes itself up with the pleasure of such recollections. And when Gabriel calls it "the very taste of time," he might be thinking of more than this particular harvest associated with Rosie. Compare the description of the scene before Ida's rape:

> It was a perfect autumn day, full of light and woody smells, glittering and crisp. We wandered far away from the camp, across the hill and down into another valley where the bushes were heavy with fruit. Ida sang as we picked. We ate our fill of the tender berries. They tasted of summer and sunshine. Disaster waits for moments like this, biding its time.[56]

There is a connection: gathering berries, Gabriel finds Rosie and loses Ida; the blackberries contain all the sweetness one may imagine ("summer and sunshine"), while the currants are bitter with future woe. If the circus is to stand for the secret plot of *Birchwood*, this might signify what happens to Rosie. While Gabriel claims that she simply died during the famine, it might be that Ida's fate mirrors Rosie's. Gangraped, beaten, damaged beyond recovery, she dies because Gabriel abandoned her – even if he did not mean to, simply failing to stay with her to protect her from harm.

Such a death would certainly make sense in view of Rosie's funeral. What a terrifying scene that is: the procession is headed by the flood of running rats, then an angry priest, Rosie's mad grandmother, the dressed-up "Strongbow" character from the town (why is he there? is he a proxy for Michael?), and the coffin carried by four emaciated men. Grotesque, contrived, sinister, the scene quickly switches into dark comedy, as constables arrive and Silas seems to orchestrate a grand circus act:

> They all began to shout at once. The priest waved his fists, Strongbow stamped his feet and rumbled menacingly, and Sergeant Trouncer bellowed at the constable, who drew his truncheon and made to clamber up on the caravan. Silas kicked him on the side of the head, and as he toppled backward in a swoon he brought down Trouncer with him, and Trouncer clutched at Strongbow, who fell on the priest, and the four of them collapsed in a heap, flailing and roaring, and the cross poked the priest in the eye. Silas gleefully clapped his hands on his

> knees, the old woman shrieked, Mario began to laugh, and then the coffin exploded. Screws flew out of their sockets like a volley of shots, the lid flew open, boards splintered, and the corpse, O! that terrible swollen thing, slid down between the shoulders of the crouching bearers and rolled across the ground shedding a foul bandage in its wake like a snail's trail.[57]

If the first part seemed borrowed from a Grim fairytale or a Gothic novel, the second appears clipped from some slapstick comedy, a film from the 1950s, with ridiculous characters and ungainly gestures. Yet, a sense of horror remains, undimmed but rather magnified by the lenses of two conventions, refusing to be neutralized: the corpse, "that terrible swollen thing," in which the girl once loved is utterly unrecognizable.

It seems likely that the explosion comes too early, precisely because Silas's caravan is blocking the way, and the procession has to stop. Without obstacles, it might have reached a spot where the British occupants were gathered, and the explosion would be a revenge of some kind – perhaps, vengeance for Rosie's death, effected by the likes of the IRA. It is obvious that the funeral does not happen as described – both the cinematic quality of the episode and the role the circus plays in it suggest its double fictionality. Most likely, Gabriel is attempting to conquer the guilt he feels about Rosie's death, or rather the way she was made to die, by weaving such artifices. But the violence, the horror, the shame, and the terrible confusion of this Totentanz are still legible in the scene.

Yet, while Rosie's funeral and the connection between the berry-gathering scenes indicate the nature of Rosie's death, there may be more to her fate that haunts Gabriel. When he speaks of finding Rosie's "wound," it is still too early for the gangrape that might be her cause of death. Still, a wound it is – which most likely means that the girl is not a virgin. And the novel contains a highly unnerving scene, which may explain this. Soon after Gabriel's intimate moment with Rosie is interrupted, they hear a gunshot and see Gabriel's father:

> Rosie was crouched by the edge of the trees with her head in her hands, and off to her left there was Papa, legs braced wide apart, smoking gun to his shoulder, a ridiculously stylised illustration of the archetypal hunter. Rosie sank to her knees, cowering in fright, with her arms still around her head. She lifted one elbow and peered out at him from under it. He looked from her to us, to the girl again. His moustache twitched, and one eyebrow jumped up his forehead. He lowered the gun, stood undecided for a moment, and then backed off into the trees, bowing under the boughs. Rosie began to howl. Michael softly laughed.[58]

The girl's fright is exaggerated, just as Joseph's figure is "ridiculously stylized." The scene turns into a tableau: the two are positioned as the hunter and his quarry, his *wounded* prey. Joseph's amusement and Rosie's cries seem to suggest more than an accidental startlement – in this book of puzzles and charades, the scene may be read as a revelation of the unstated connection between the girl and this man with a *smoking gun* - one of violence and violation. If Gabriel sees it this way, it would give him a strong motive to murder his father.

A confirmation that Gabriel is the real murderer may be found in the strange nickname which Silas, the paternal figure of the circus, uses for Gabriel: Caligula. While literally, it means "one of small feet,"[59] it sends us off to one of the infamous Roman emperors, among whose sins was the murder of his uncle and adoptive father, Emperor Tyberious – allegedly, Caligula smothered him with a pillow. Caligula was also a famously cruel circus master: he would command to release the wild beasts which would devour part of the audience when he was bored with the performance. Gabriel describes himself as "not a cruel child, only a cold one, and I feared boredom above all else."[60]

Besides the nickname, there is a pattern in the novel indicating that patricide runs in the family: Joseph Godkin cunningly opened the door for his father, Simon, to run off into the forest and perish there. Joseph's purpose was to come into his inheritance – like father, like son. Rosie's fate would certainly add to Gabriel's desire to be rid of his father, who not only destroys the innocence of the child, but also squanders away Gabriel's precious Birchwood, selling it off piece by piece.

And what of Beatrice's fate? We are told that she is no longer at Birchwood when Gabriel "returns" – and that she is dead by the time he begins his narrative. Joseph hints to Gabriel, as he is about to send him off to school, that she is also to go "into a home."[61] Cotter, that

strange, timeless figure who supposedly allies himself with Silas to slaughter the Lawlesses and, later, the "Molly McGuires," says that Beatrice died in a madhouse.[62] However, her madness, judging by Gabriel's descriptions in the first part of the novel, is a kind of costume she puts on to protect herself in the poisonous atmosphere of Birchwood, with its incest, violence, secret intrigues, and to allow her some freedom in accomplishing her revenge. This is, literally, what happens – she turns "mad" as she puts on the dress of Grandma Godkin, and detaches herself from everyone – her comment, to Gabriel, at that moment: "poor boy, (...) *All alone*" seems to reflect this.[63]

Sending Beatrice to an asylum of some kind and Gabriel to a school seems to be the plot Martha and Joseph came up with to finally have the house to themselves. But Beatrice, in her guise of a madwoman descending from the attic (that is where she "finds" her madness), seems able to spy on them and predict their movements. And she appears to get her splendid revenge by suggesting to Martha that her son is inside the burning hayshed, thus sending her sister-in-law to a death in the flames. If so, gentle soul that she is, in the aftermath, locked up in the institution, she would suffer from the pain of remorse and loneliness, and all that woe would make death desirable and, no doubt, within easy reach. But would jealousy be enough for Beatrice to do something as wicked as murder? And if there were no Michael, why would Martha make such a desperate gesture?

The Burning Hayshed – the Burning Circus

In an attempt to unravel this, let us examine the hayshed fire scene more closely.[64] Gabriel suggests that Rosie set the hayshed on fire in revenge for his desertion. Earlier, however, he mentions seeing Michael going in the direction of the hayshed – and, if Michael is an imaginary double of the narrator, this might indicate that Gabriel is the one who causes the fire. Of course, his own account contradicts this: he narrates observing the fire, watching the reactions of the adults, hearing Beatrice's suggestion that Martha's son is in the shed, then witnessing Martha's *auto-da-fé*, and the firemen at their awkward and farcically ineffectual attempts to put out the fire and save the woman. He is in the position of a spectator, and indeed, the entire episode smacks of a theatrical show of some kind: everything has a strongly stylized, fantastical cast.

The scene begins with a voice – "a voice which seemed to be in the room with me said, very calmly, *here it comes*"[65] – as if this were the cool, cruel Doppelgänger announcing the beginning of a show. Next, he describes seeing "Mama and Aunt Martha [who] stood confronting each other, very strange, very still, like some figures guarding the doorway."[66] He is underscoring the weirdness of this vision, and what is to come is stranger still: Beatrice is to act completely out of character, wickedly suggesting that Martha's son is in that fire, and, even more uncharacteristically, Martha is to walk into the fire, like a puppet pulled by the strings of her puppeteer – in a completely unbelievable, mad gesture of self-sacrifice. Gabriel describes her movement as incredibly theatrical: "she lifted her arm to brush the sweat from her forehead with a languid, lazy, stylized gesture of weariness. Acting still!"[67]

Then, the father, is described in another "performance": "Papa opened his mouth and bawled, angrily, terribly, and covered his face with his hands, and in that theatrical pose I left him, as a fireman, no doubt acting out some cherished notion of heroism, grabbed me up out of the path of a non-existent danger and went pounding off around the house to the front door, where Mama still stood, still smiling placidly."[68] There is an odd confusion between active and passive verbs: "I left him" suggests voluntary action, while it references an act of being carried away, passively. One could suspect that Gabriel's memory is embroidering here, but there is more: I would insist that the entire scene is imagined, or rather, retrospectively recreated. Gabriel is nowhere near the house – having started the fire, he is, indeed, at the shed, and this is why the fireman carries him off, rather than trying to save Martha. In other words, Gabriel is the actual cause of her death, whether or not Beatrice said anything to Martha while the fire raged in the shed. Gabriel identifies the fireman, who is depicted as a kind of clown – winking, dropping his helmet, rushing off – as the angel of death, and this conflation of the

comic and the tragic – or even the melodramatic, since this seems to be the mode of the performance – foreshadows the circus adventure, and another fire scene.

The fire that burns the circus caravans appears at the very end of "Air and Angels" and coincides with the death of Magnus, the great storyteller and magician. His head literally explodes in another one of those grotesque, violent scenes, and he dies trying to save Gabriel:

> I do not know how long I stood out there, gazing into the dark. Perhaps I fell asleep on my feet. The noises came to me unnoticed at first, voices and the thud of boots, clatter of metal and wood, and an oddly familiar crackling. (. . .) One of the caravans was on fire, and there were soldiers on the road scurrying about against the glare like tin men. (. . .) I set off at a run toward the blazing caravan. Magnus overtook me. *"Get back, Gabriel, get back*!" A challenge rang out nearby and I veered away, flame spurted from the muzzle of a rifle, and over my shoulder I saw by that brief livid light Magnus halt as the back of his head exploded. He went down like a stricken spider, arms and legs spinning, and in his place there popped up before me, like a sad and lovely aunt sally, the image of him dancing in a field in April rain with mouth-organ music wreathed around him like flowers.[69]

This scene is terrifying, but somehow it is far less fantastic than the description of the hayshed fire and Martha's senseless *auto-da-fé*. The crucial difference is the presence of the soldiers, the authorized agents of violence. And if we remember that this is Ireland, and the soldiers are, of course, English, and the novel is written in 1973, pieces of the puzzle begin to fall together: behind all the stylization, there is the bleak and horrible historical fact of the Troubles, with all the explosions, fires, and violent deaths. But let us linger a moment: if the two scenes are connected, what does it mean?

The scene is a contamination of the hayshed fire: instead of the house, there is an empty pub; the soldiers seem to replace the firemen; the comparison of Magnus to a spider echoes a similar phrase in the earlier scene ("Papa, looming up behind me like a huge pale spider").[70] The *danse macabre* that Magnus seems to be performing is made up of several overlapping elements: the dying fall and a memory of a bucolic dance, plus a reference to an old English game of "Aunt Sally" – a pub garden game during which sticks would be thrown at the head of a doll, traditionally featuring an old woman's head with a clay pipe in the mouth. This is a very peculiar conflation: Magnus is androgynised, as well as idealized – he seems both the god Pan and a silly woman; the fall is reversed in the memory of the dance, and the reference to the game further confuses things – the image that pops up is "sad and lovely," not that of an old hag's head being brought down by the missile thrown at it. And the word "aunt," of course, sends us off to Martha. Gabriel (and his author) never uses words accidentally.

There is not much, one would think, in common between Martha and Magnus, except both are, to Gabriel, the tellers of stories – Martha reads to him, Magnus talks; both die protecting him. But Gabriel's father is also there, through the reference to that spider. Gabriel says about Magnus: "of all the creatures I have lost I miss most his valiant and fastidious spirit."[71] Perhaps, he is forced to create this wonderful figure because this is the only way for him to grieve for his parents without forgetting how he hated them.

Mothers and Lovers

And hate them he did. We can observe it through another reflection in the circus episode. If Beatrice is recreated in Ida, Martha's equivalent seems to be Sybil, also red-haired, cruel, and – if we are to believe Gabriel – the mother of the twins Justin and Juliette. There is a disturbing scene in the novel when Sybil reaches out to Gabriel, seeming to demand something from him, in gestures that belong to the theater of seduction. At the same time, there is a kind of dull desperation in it, as if she were not just seducing him, but attempting to make him into her child, an extension of herself. Gabriel describes the attempt as an absolute failure – he is cold and passive, as always. But if the scene is meant to signify something that happened in the story-world of the Birchwood household, it may be interpreted as Martha's incestual seduction of Gabriel, and simultaneously her attempt to make him love her as his mother, despite his detachment.

Another suggestion of what might have been going on between Martha and Gabriel may be found in the odd episode with Mag, ill-fitting to the story of the circus adventure. Red-haired,

like Martha and Sybil, she is a farm girl of dimensions much larger than Gabriel's. He has a somewhat unsettling sexual experience with her – she is frankly offering herself to him, while he does not seem to know what to do. His embarrassment and inexperience are at variance with the way he times the episode: if it is to happen during his sojourn with the circus, he would have already known at least some intimacy with Rosie; besides, at the beginning of the narrative he speaks of the encounter with Mag as something that happened "many years" after Rosie, which cannot be, as the affair with Rosie supposedly ends just before he runs off with the circus, and the whole circus adventure takes up only a single year. Gabriel is "misplacing" time, once again, confusing his tracks. Mag may be a corrupted, contaminated image of Martha – the experience is out of time, out of place, dreadful, entirely incongruous, and yet unforgettable. Elke D'hoker points to the replication of Martha in Mag's image in *Visions of Alterity*, though she also seems to see Martha in Rosie[72] – and here I would disagree, as Rosie belongs with Beatrice and Ida.

Incest, then, is also something that is referred to through a gesture of misplacement, shifted out of the narrative, but left recoverable through the mirrored story. Indeed, the tangle between the members of the family is far more important in the novel than the whole intrigue with inheritance. It would have been obvious to Martha and Michael that there would be nothing to inherit by the end of the story: Joseph is selling off Birchwood, bit by bit. None of the struggles for ascendancy between the siblings make any sense. And even Gabriel's love for Birchwood, which turns into an aching nostalgia, is too much for a boy of sixteen or seventeen who leaves home for a year, even if he comes back to find all his relatives and loved ones dead. If, however, growing up as a lonely adolescent, he found in Birchwood a space of freedom which he lost as he was sent off to a boarding school, and would keep losing it repeatedly, every school year, feeling miserable while he was away from it, becoming homesick, imagining himself the owner of a glorious kingdom, – then his nostalgia would be quite natural – after all, it is "a longing for what never was."[73]

It is extraordinary how shamelessly he describes in great detail events he could not have seen, or even heard about – the wooing of Beatrice by Joseph, the wedding, the circus invading Birchwood on the day of his birth, relations between Joseph, Martha, Beatrice and Granny Godkin before he was there to observe them. The details seem vivid and convincing – if he conflates several moments in time into a single event, which is later replicated in echoes, then his self-assurance is only natural. He describes what he has not experienced through the memory of what he has. And then that memory becomes a projection into the future, perhaps several times over, to produce the impression of a circular journey.

This tactic of silent conflation, an exchange of details between events, is employed to sustain the confusion between the two mothers – Martha, vicious and clingy, and Beatrice, gentle and quiet, even at her most desperate. For instance, in the early part of the novel, there is a description of the picnic, during which "Mama," who seems to be Beatrice, sits silent over a book, later to follow Gabriel's father, whom he glances, still later, making love to a half-visible woman under the Cotter's wall. It is supposed to be a momentous event, which reveals a secret harmony to the boy. Yet, we know not how old he is at the moment, and how much he can understand; it is strange that he is left alone in the forest, even if for a brief moment; and the image in the Cotter's cottage resembles the Freudian primal scene far too closely. It seems constructed of bits and pieces, some authentic, and some borrowed, imagined, or projected. Commenting on the Wordsworthian quality of the scene, Elke D'hoker writes: "Perhaps, Gabriel's epiphany does not really afford a glimpse into the hidden harmony of life; perhaps, this sudden sense of order is not really experienced, but retrospectively established in function of his narrative."[74] I find this suspicion justified, not only because of the lyricism injected into the scene, but primarily because there is a repetition in the novel – and, as I have tried to demonstrate, these are a way for Gabriel to confuse his tracks.

The scene has its equivalent on the day Granny Godkin explodes, but this time it is between Joseph and Martha, and Gabriel emphasizes the resemblance by claiming to experience a sense of *déjà vu*

while watching it. Did the scene happen twice, with different women? Or, does the narrator simply shuffle his memories together with pictures borrowed or stolen from other books and fantasized episodes to achieve his purpose? Is he playing the game of patience Granny Godkin used to do as "her alibi?" I would insist on the second option, distrusting this narrator, because he is, after all, Mercury, the god of thieves and a crafty dissembler.

The Puzzle Maker and the Juggler

Gabriel's quest in the novel is not for his twin sister, nor for the meaning of his experiences, but for the ultimate "rosy grail" – the perfection of artistic vision which would make the world whole, even if only for a brief moment. This is signaled in a scene when Michael is first introduced to Birchwood, and Gabriel shows him around the house, finally bringing him to his own room, to look at a puzzle he has put together:

> My most precious toy, if that is the right word, was a magnificent circular jigsaw puzzle of over two thousand tiny wafer-thin pieces. After weeks of intermittent labour varying between a furious panicstricken scrabbling and the smiling swoon of delight when the right piece, the only possible piece, fell into its place in the mosaic, I had assembled out of it a glorious gold and blue painting of a Renaissance madonna, a picture which, in the completed puzzle, glowed with a sense of light and purity, of palpable intensity, which was mysteriously absent from its sibling reproduced on the lid of its box. (. . .) Abruptly, before I could stop him, he bent and picked up the board. (. . .) the puzzle glided off, seemed to hang intact in mid-air for a moment, and then fell to the carpet and shattered with an absurdly inadequate, heartbreaking little clatter. (. . .) It was not the wasted work that pained me, but the unavoidable recognition of the fragility of all that beauty.[75]

It is telling that the puzzle assembled out of separate pieces seems to possess a kind of beauty "mysteriously absent" from the unfragmented original. What is the difference? The image on the cover is someone else's artwork, while the painstakingly and delightedly composed puzzle is Gabriel's own. He repossesses the lovely vision and finds "light and purity," "palpable intensity" in this re-collected version. It no longer matters that another artist stands behind the image; that artist disappeared and became irrelevant the moment the painting was fragmented. This must be why Prospero never appears in the novel. Thus, fragmentation seems the key to artistic delight – and freedom, and perfection, and so much more. This lesson will be reenacted by Gabriel in the circus episode:

> I began to play a game, idly at first and then with some excitement. I would close my eyes and then, every few seconds or so, blink rapidly. Not much of a game? Each time I blinked I carried back into the gloom an image of arrested movement, the old man frozen in mid-air, Silas with his arm uplifted, the fat woman with a finger stuck in her red eye, and it came to me with the clarity and beauty of a mathematical statement that all movement is composed of an infinity of minute stillnesses, not one of which is exactly the same as any other and yet not so different either. It was enormously pleasing, this discovery of fixity within continuity. I elbowed my way outside, and out there in the fragrant darkness and the silence, yes, it was the same, I mean the same principle of continually fluctuating stasis held good, but the shifts and stillnesses here were vast and difficult to distinguish, but I distinguished them. And I saw something else, namely that this was how I lived, glancing every now and then out of darkness and catching sly time in the act, but such glimpses were rare and brief and of hardly any consequence, for time, time would go on anyway, without *my* vigilance.[76]

The recognition of the nature of reality – "catching sly time in the act" – seems transcendental, and metafictional at the same time. Indeed, perhaps the two are the same in any invented world. And one may think that in his narrative, Gabriel is trying to mimic that essential fragmentation to move the reader – trick the reader, the way the circus audiences are willingly tricked, – to begin the re-creation of the vision of his world, whole and entire, and palpably intense. This is the meaning of *recollection* in Gabriel's text: *re-collection* of the world out of bits and pieces, out of "infinity of minute stillnesses" – those stills, frozen frames, cutouts which he makes us see so vividly. In this kind of *re-collection* the artistic effort is transferred from the narrator to the reader, and this is precisely how the magic trick can work: the reader's memory and imagination are now repossessing the story, making it into a puzzle of their own. But if so, one must also remember how fragile such re-assembled vision is;

and, eventually, Gabriel's discovery as he watches the crumbling puzzle seems to be that it is, after all, insufficient. There is another way:

> Michael took from his pocket a chipped blue building block, a marble and a rubber ball. He began to juggle. At first it went clumsily, he dropped the ball, hit himself on the nose with the block, but then all abruptly changed, a rhythm appeared, one could almost hear it, like the airy beat of a bird's wing, and in his hands he spun a trembling pale blue hoop of light. His uplifted face gleamed from the effort of concentration as he leaned this way and that, following a sudden dip of the block, the wayward flight of the ball, and I found myself thinking of air and angels, of silence, of translucent planes of pale blue glass in space gliding through illusory, gleaming and perfect combinations. My puzzle seemed a paltry thing compared to this beauty, this, this *harmony*.[77]

How wonderful it is that Michael is juggling with disparate items, something that – if anyone ever tried it – is much harder to do than juggling with, say, objects of the same weight and shape. Harmony here is created as if on a wholly different level. There is a rhythm, a melody, but also a silence – and this is when Gabriel uses the phrase "air and angels" for the first time. The scene is not simply a foreshadowing of the circus adventure – as I argued, the circus and all its characters are part of Gabriel's make-believe, just as Michael is. The idea of the juggler creating his impossible harmony with "translucent planes of pale blue glass in space gliding through illusory, gleaming and perfect combination" is a metaphor for artistic exploit, which does not follow another artist – there is no original here, only a strange, and somewhat awkward act, which does not last for long, but it is enough, it is a thing in itself.

It seems undeniable that Gabriel fragments his story, breaking it into scenes, with many reflections in "a cracked mirror" of his memory. But this is only the first step in his elaborate performance. The heart of his act is juggling with disparate fragments, not just those drawn from his own experience and imagination, but also borrowed from literature, history, tradition. The essence of juggling is replacement: making the movement from one element to another so smooth it appears there is no movement at all, no change, just a vibrating continuity. Through this act, he becomes the master conjurer: he switches one object – scene – character – with another, similar and different at the same time. He transcends the limitations of storytelling by refusing to become the puzzle maker; instead, he makes the reader see the illusory combinations of plot, theme and characterization; telling one story, he creates multiple, perhaps an infinity.

This essay demonstrated how Banville's narrator juggled with the elements of his story. The act is accomplished in plain sight: it may be seen in the replacement of one mother with another, one twin with another. This study of the novel attempted to go deeper, to recover the bits of Gabriel's world which he so beautifully substituted with their semi-equivalents. Some were quite obvious (Rose/Rosie)[78]; others more subtle (Ida/Beatrice and Rosie; Sybil/Martha); still others so complex they may seem preposterous (Magnus as Martha *and* Joseph Godkin, in one androgynous vision). Identifying the moments when the sleight of hand happens suggests a reading of the family story that is even more tragic than the surface tale. But if something was indeed glimpsed, Gabriel's skill is far greater than he admits, and we must remember that we are not *re-collecting* a puzzle; therefore, no definite answers can be granted. After all, "the great works maintain their mystery because they withhold themselves."[79] There is a great pleasure in simply watching the juggler-conjurer's performance, but there is another, perhaps greater delight in catching the sly artist in the act, recognizing at least some of his tricks, and thereby grasping just how clever and infinitely mesmerizing that performance is.

Notes

1. John Banville, *Birchwood* (London: Picador, 1998), 76–77.
2. *Birchwood*, 94.
3. Vladimir Nabokov, "An Evening of Russian Poetry," *Selected Poems*, ed. Thomas Karshan (New York, Alfred A. Knopf, 2012), 136. Note that this poem also contains lines describing a birch tree "on tip-toe," and a circus magician putting away his apparatus.

4. Francis C. Molloy, "The Search for Truth: The Fiction of John Banville," *Irish University Review*, vol. 11, no. 1 (1981): 32 [29–51]. Joseph McMinn interprets this feature as Banville's fulfillment of "Flann O'Brien's recommendations that fictional characters be allowed 'self-determination.'" – "Naming the World: Language and Experience in John Banville's Fiction," *Irish University Review* vol. 23, no. 2 (1993): 186 [183–196].
5. John Banville, *The Singularities* (Croydon: Swift Press, 2023) 22.
6. Banville admitted the connection between the two characters: "it was a kind of personal return, a personal revisionism almost. So, I consciously gave the second Gabriel the same name." He adds, however: "But one shouldn't read too much into it." Earl G. Ingersoll and John Cusatis, eds., *Conversations with John Banville* (Jackson: University Press of Mississippi, 2020), 7. These statements come from an early interview of 1988, and perhaps at that time the writer was not yet aware of the extent to which the multiverse of his fiction would rely on this kind of inexact repetition. Banville also stated to Imhof that "*Mefisto* makes many overt and covert allusions to Birchwood. I wanted to signal – to myself, mainly – the fact that I was returning to what one may call the realm of pure imagination out of which *Birchwood* was produced. No more history, no more facts! – Rüdiger Imhof, "John Banville: Interview by Rudiger Imhof," *ILS* 6 (spring 1987), 68.
7. Gabriel Swan will feature again in the biography of Adam Godley (that god-game again) in *The Singularities*, the novel in which the Godkin twins (female, this time round) and Nockter (a servant in Birchwood and a kidnapper in *The Singularities*) play episodic roles. And the circus will appear in *Eclipse* as a much more elaborate affair, featuring characters who might be Gabriel, Mario, Silas and an aged woman, possibly Sybil or Ada (she plays a trumpet, performs as the magician's assistant and wears two wigs by turns, black and white).
8. John Banville rarely speaks of *Birchwood* in his interviews, and when he does, he dismissively calls it his "Irish" novel – and a dead end. Cf. Ingersoll and Cusatis, eds., *Conversations with John Banville*, 5, 27, 28, 41.
9. William Shakespeare, *The Tempest*, Act IV, Scene I.
10. *Birchwood*, 32–33.
11. Rüdiger Imhof, *John Banville: A Critical Introduction* (Dublin: Wolfhound Press, 1997), 61.
12. "Author Events: John Banville, *The Singularities*." John Banville in conversation with Colum McCann, 7 November 2022, 26:57–27:12. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=noX-BMGOHcA&t=2612s.
13. "Author Events," 13:36.
14. *Birchwood*, 13.
15. Catullus, cited in *Birchwood*, 7.
16. Molloy, "The Search for Truth," 44.
17. Mika Momoo, "Only Echoes and Coincidences: Textual Authority in John Banville's *Birchwood*," *Journal of Irish Studies*, vol. 22 (2007): 43.
18. *Birchwood*, 12.
19. Joseph McMinn, *The Supreme Fictions of John Banville* (Manchester and New York: Manchester UP, 1999), 33.
20. McMinn, *The Supreme Fictions*, 35.
21. *Birchwood*, 90.
22. *Birchwood*, 71.
23. *Birchwood*, 68.
24. McMinn speaks of "calculated transparency" of the names in *Birchwood*, but identifies different connections than I do, linking Beatrice to Dante, Silas to Sheridan Le Fanu's Uncle Silas, and Rose and Sybil to "traditional or conventional connotations of romantic idealism." McMinn, "Naming the World," 186.
25. *Birchwood*, 135.
26. *Birchwood*, 120, 151.
27. Cf. McMinn, *The Supreme Fictions*, 38. Imhof enumerates the excessive doubles within that episode, which is another sign of the metafictionality – *John Banville*, 66. Derek Hand writes that "it can be argued that the second section is a retelling of the first part" – Derek Hand, *John Banville: Exploring Fictions* (Dublin: The Liffey Press, 2002), 29. Francis C. Molloy writes: "There is a timelessness about the members of the circus. Their names – Silas, Sybil, Rainbird, Magnus – indicate that they do not belong to any particular locality; rather, they wander from one place to another" – Molloy, "The Search for Truth.," 38. Neil Corcoran suggests that the circus is "a knowing amalgam of literary fragments (Herman Hesse, Alain Fournier, Dickens's *Hard Times*)" as well as "the opportunity for a hallucinatory transmission of some of the most intractable facts of Irish history, from the Cromwellian atrocities of the seventeenth century, through the Famines of 1845 and afterward, to the terrorism of the 'Molly Maguires' and the Black and Tans in the War of Independence." – Neil Corcoran, *After Yeats and Joyce: Reading Modern Irish Fiction* (Oxford: Oxford UP, 1997), 53.
28. Another intertextual pointer to the connection between Beatrice and Ida, Ada's sister, is the echo of Nabokov's *Ada or Ardor: A Family Chronicle* in the names of the circus twins. In Nabokov's text, the children of twin sisters turn out to be direct siblings. This pattern is reflected in the incestual plot of *Birchwood*, with a difference which makes it all the more suggestive. McMinn notes *Ada* as "a strong presence in *Birchwood*," though he does not comment on the false motherhood element – *The Supreme Fictions.*, 168.
29. Elke D'hoker, *Visions of Alterity: Representation in the Works of John Banville* (Amsterdam and New York: Rodopi, 2004), 2.

30. The novel was first published in 1973.
31. "Author Events.," 2:35–4:02.
32. The British troops were infamously deployed during The Troubles in Northern Ireland. The geography of the novel is fuzzy, and it is unclear where exactly Birchwood is located, though references to Strongbow indicate that it most likely coincides with Wexford, Banville's birthplace. However, the terrorist violence was not limited to Northern Ireland but spread to the Republic of Ireland as well.
33. Some critics have already noted the correspondences – cf.: Hand, *John Banville.*, 37–38; Heather Ingman, "Anglo-Ireland: the Big House Novel in Transition" in Eve Patten, ed., *Irish Literature in Transition, 1940–1980* (Cambridge: Cambridge UP, 2020), 265; Eoghan Smith, *John Banville: Art and Authenticity* (New York: Peter Lang, 2014), 33.
34. *Birchwood*, 33.
35. *Birchwood*, 168.
36. *Birchwood*, 172.
37. *Birchwood*, 95.
38. Imhof, *John Banville*, 74.
39. *Birchwood*, 3.
40. John Banville, *Eclipse* (New York: Vintage, 2002), 55.
41. To cite just a few: McMinn, *The Supreme Fictions.*, 32; John Kenny, *John Banville* (Dublin, Portland: Irish Academic Press, 2009), 62. Imhof cites several reviews of *Birchwood* that identify the conventions employed in its structure – Imhof, *John Banville.*, 66–69, 74. Mika Momoo writes that Banville "seems to dissect the traditional form of the Big House novel, cutting it into pieces and stuffing it with his own dark sense of humour" – "Only Echoes.," 42. Neil Corcoran states that the plot of *Birchwood* "gives Banville scope to range through a theatrical stock or museum of Big House effects, parading his own ingenuity as the maker of a new kind of patchwork fiction out of the bits and pieces of apparently almost unusably over-familiar motifs." – Corcoran, *After Yeats and Joyce.*, 53. Discussing the convention of the Big House novel, Susanne Burgstaller states: "Banville takes over, reshapes and parodies its stereotypes, characters, plot structures and social codes, working within the form in order to subvert it." - "'This Lawless House' – John Banville's Postmodernist Treatment of the Big-House Motif in *Birchwood* and *The Newton Letter*" in Otto Rauchbauer, ed., *Ancestral Voices: The Big House in Anglo-Irish Literature* (Dublin: Lilliput Press, 1992), 240. See also Vera Kreilkamp, *The Anglo-Irish Novel and the Big House* (Syracuse: Syracuse UP, 1998), 248–9.
42. Ingersoll and Cusatis, eds., *Conversations.*, 27.
43. Imhof, "An Interview with John Banville," *Irish University Review*, 11:1 (1981), 11.
44. Banville mentions that his hero in *The Book of Evidence* "is a mere voice, not a character" – and this appears to be a feature shared, to an extent, by all his narrators, perhaps because of the strong sense of the instability of self that transpires through Banville's texts. Ingersoll and Cusatis, eds., *Conversations.*, 27.
45. *Birchwood*, 31.
46. Imhof, *John Banville*, 76.
47. The same structure appears in *The Singularities*, a novel that will collect and re-invent many characters from Banville's previous books. Freddy Montgomery from *The Book of Evidence* gets here an alternative future, released from prison not after ten (as in *Ghosts*), but twenty-five years, and invents a new name for himself – Felix Mordaunt, itself a combination of two names used in other novels, Felix from *Mefisto* and *Ghosts*, and Morden in *Athena* and *The Sea*. Introducing himself, he says: "The name, by the way, is Mordaunt" – a structure all too similar to Gabriel's self-introduction. – *The Singularities*, 35.
48. Marcin Rytel pointed out that while "Godkin" associates the narrator with the omnipotent Godhead, it is only as His next-of-kin, and so, in that very phrase, it also undermines his narratorial powers; 'Godley' functions in a similar way: only "like God," but not quite God.
49. Richard de Clare, a 12th-century Anglo-Norman nobleman who took an active part in the conquest of Ireland, and who was named Strongbow in 14th-century records.
50. *Birchwood*, 40.
51. *Birchwood*, 169–170.
52. Imhof, "An Interview," 11.
53. *Birchwood*, 13.
54. *Birchwood*, 13.
55. *Birchwood*, 65.
56. *Birchwood*, 145.
57. *Birchwood*, 150–1.
58. *Birchwood*, 72.
59. A phrase and a quality that will reappear in numerous books by Banville – for instance, Adam Godley, the scientist in *The Infinities* and *The Singularities* has the dainty feet; the artist Oliver Orme in *The Blue Guitar* is

another such figure and Carlo Grace in *The Sea* is yet another; even Quirke, a pathologist who is the protagonist of Banville's (or rather Benjamin Black's) "thrillers," is described this way.

60. *Birchwood*, 76.
61. *Birchwood*, 91.
62. *Birchwood*, 160.
63. *Birchwood*, 87–8.
64. The idea for this episode might have been borrowed from Nabokov's *Ada*: in it, the burning barn is observed by two siblings, and it is that night that they become lovers. Of course, Banville (or rather, Gabriel) makes his own story out of Nabokov's, but the rudiments are the same: desire, incest, role acting, destruction.
65. *Birchwood*, 96.
66. *Birchwood*, 96.
67. *Birchwood*, 97.
68. *Birchwood*, 97.
69. *Birchwood*, 153–4.
70. *Birchwood*, 97.
71. *Birchwood*, 120.
72. D'hoker, *Visions of Alterity*, 143.
73. *Eclipse*, 14.
74. D'hoker, *Visions of Alterity*, 62.
75. *Birchwood*, 42.
76. *Birchwood*, 128.
77. *Birchwood*, 43.
78. Mark O'Connell writes: "'Rosie' is 'Rose' with an 'I' inserted into it." Cf. *John Banville's Narcissistic Fictions: The Spectral Self* (London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2013), 75.
79. "West Cork Literary Festival. Author Events: John Banville," Banville in conversation with Christin Leach, 3 November 2023, 36:21. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7YvGhyhRe-k.

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Notes on contributor

Irena Księżopolska, PhD, is an Assistant Professor at the Institute of English Studies, University of Warsaw, Poland. Her most recent book is Ian McEwan: Subversive Readings, Informed Misreadings (Routledge, 2024); she also published on Vladimir Nabokov, Virginia Woolf, Muriel Spark and other writers. Currently, she is working on a book on John Banville.

ORCID

Irena Księżopolska http://orcid.org/0000-0001-9074-8941

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